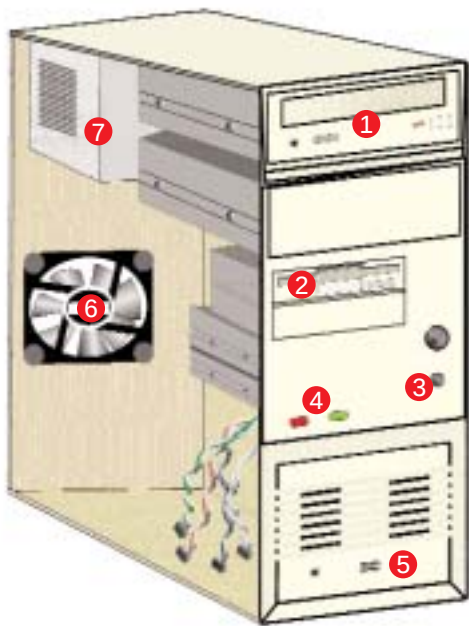




HDD LED blinks when the hard drive is being accessed, while the Power LED normally blinks when the system goes into standby.

6 The front panel: Normally has a grille plate through which air ventilation takes place.

7 The system or chassis fan: It acts as an exhaust fan for the PC and keeps the PC cool. Keep this dust-free.

8 SMPS: The Switch Mode Power Supply (SMPS) converts and steps down AC voltage to DC for the components of the computer.



Facts

- A configuration comprising a medium speed processor, a GeForce 3 graphics card and a 40X CD-Writer is just enough to overload a 250 W SMPS or make your system unstable.
- You can also modify your casing and add additional fans to achieve greater levels of airflow within the system for efficient cooling.
- Place a packet of silica gel inside the chassis to keep the components free from moisture.
- Some cases provide an intermediate connector for cables, such as the ones for the hard disk and power LED, that run from the front panel to the motherboard. They prove to be of great help while disassembling the motherboard for servicing, etc.

The Future

Initially, there was not much to choose from in the cabinet market. However, these cases have now incorporated a lot of changes that make them worth their price. Features such as screwless cases, front panel USB and sound ports, etc., have enhanced their appeal. Improved spacious designs provide for better airflow and make room for additional system fans. On the whole, cabinets have drastically reduced the possibility of damage to internal components due to heat, and have simplified PC assembling or disassembling. Chassis modifications are also becoming popular. Do expect a lot of see-through panels and neon lights for cabinets in the future.



Buying Tips

MOTHERBOARD FORM FACTOR:

The primary factor that decides the cabinet size is the motherboard. The form factors currently available for a motherboard are Baby AT, ATX and Micro-ATX.

DRIVE BAYS: Ensure that a new cabinet has at least three 5.25-inch drive bays to allow for future addition of devices such as a CD-RW drive, etc.

ADDITIONAL FANS: Check whether your cabinet has enough room for additional cooling fans.

SMPS: Generally, cabinets come with a 250-watt SMPS. However, the SMPS gets overloaded the moment you add extra peripherals or upgrade to a faster processor. So opt for an SMPS with a higher power rating that allows you to upgrade and add more devices in the future. Currently, the SMPSES available provide power ratings in the range of 300 watts to 550 watts.

INSIDE SPACE: Verify whether the cabinet is roomy enough to add or replace components with minimal effort. Also, ensure that the hard disk or CD-ROM do not overlap the CPU or the RAM on the motherboard inside the chassis.

- 5.25-inch optical drives bay :** The CD or DVD-ROM drives are inserted here.
- 3.25-inch drive bay:** The hard drives, ZIP drives and floppy drives are placed here.
- Power Button:** The main power button of the system.
- Reset switch:** You will hit this button often—it restarts Windows.
- Power and Hard Disk Drive LEDs:** The power and hard disk drive-access LEDs are the status indicators for the system. The

Quick Find	
YOU NEED	A cost effective cabinet
Basic Use	
LOOK FOR	A cabinet that has a couple of optical drives bays, a couple of 3-½ FDD bays and a couple of hard disk bays
YOU NEED	A strong and good-looking cabinet
Inter Use	
LOOK FOR	An aluminium cabinet as these are very stylish
YOU NEED	A cabinet that is future proof as well as maintains a low temperature
Prof Use	
	A cabinet that has a powerful SMPS, provides ample space for additional systems fans, more internal space to enable good air flow, has more than 3 optical and hard disk drive bays